

Mousebirds

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Coliiformes
FAMILIES	1 (Coliidae)
SPECIES	6

Named for their ability to run like rodents, mousebirds scramble about branches in search of buds, leaves, or fruit. Their feet

are unique—the 2 outermost toes are reversible, and can point either forward (with the other 2 toes, for hanging), or backward (for grasping). Mousebirds live in flocks and are found only in Africa.

PERCHING

Mousebirds, such as these white-headed mousebirds, have an unusual perching posture. Using their flexible toes, they hold onto branches with their feet held level with their shoulders. They can even perch upside-down.



Colius striatus

Speckled mousebird



Location C., E., and S. Africa

Length 12–16 in (30–40 cm)
Weight 1½–2½ oz (45–75 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



This plump bird has a long tail of narrow, stiffened feathers, a stout, softly crested head, and a stubby, downcurved bill. Primarily brown and gray, it has faint barring and speckling on its wings, neck, and throat, and red legs and feet; the bill is dark gray to blackish above and lighter gray below. Like all mousebirds, it often forms groups of 4 to 20—usually consisting of pairs and some immature individuals—that sleep together in a tight cluster hanging from branches. They may

preen and even offer food to each other. At times regarded as agricultural pests, mousebirds are often exterminated in farm areas and gardens.



Trogon

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Trogoniformes
FAMILIES	1 (Trogonidae)
SPECIES	43

These brilliantly colored birds live in tropical forests in the Americas, Southeast Asia, and sub-Saharan Africa. They have short, rounded wings, a long tail, soft, often iridescent plumage, and bright patches of bare skin around the eyes. They grip branches with

their small feet, which have 2 toes pointing forward and 2 backward; uniquely, it is the first and second toes that point backward. The short bill has a wide gape for catching invertebrates in flight.

NESTING

Trogons nest in cavities, either in existing holes in tree trunks, or by digging their own holes in rotten wood or in wasp or termite nests. This slaty-tailed trogon is making a nest hole in a termite nest.



Pharomachrus mocinno

Resplendent quetzal



Location Central America

Length 14–16 in (35–40 cm)
Weight 7–8 oz (200–225 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened



The male resplendent quetzal is widely regarded as one of the world's most beautiful birds. It has brilliantly colored plumage—mainly iridescent emerald-green—and a rich crimson-colored breast. Other characteristics, unique to the male, are the exceptionally long tail coverts, which extend beyond the tail to form an elegant train, and the short, bristlelike crest. Both sexes are plump-bodied and have stout heads. This bird's habit of perching motionless for long periods makes it difficult to spot. It flies among trees looking for fruit or insects. Both parents brood the eggs—the tail feathers of the

male sticking out of the nest hole as he sits on the eggs—and share in feeding the young.



Trogon violaceus

Guianan trogon



Location S.E. Mexico to C. South America

Length 9–10 in (23–26 cm)
Weight 1½–2½ oz (45–65 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Generally solitary, this bird is mainly found in tropical rain forest and woodland (occasionally in dry brushland and farmland), in Central and South America. Males have a black and iridescent



black iridescent head

violet-blue head, a green back and upper tail, and a yellow-orange breast, while females are primarily gray. The nest consists of an excavated hole, usually in a tree but sometimes built in old termite or wasp nests. This bird feeds on fruit, insects, and other invertebrates.

barred tail feathers